How I developed Family 35

Wilbur N. Pickering, ThM PhD

I will begin with a little background. For forty years of my adult life, that life revolved around transcultural missions. Toward the end I hoped that Brazil would become a great missionary sending country. For perhaps ten years I had promoted missions in churches around that country. During the 90s I was part of the AD 2000 movement, and due to a sense of urgency, in 1996 I started a missionary training school that had the following stated objective: to prepare a type of Christian worker with the following three qualities: 1) total commitment to Christ and His Kingdom; 2) a sincere **and informed** commitment to the objective authority of the Biblical Text; 3) ability in the use of God's power in visible ways. I had in hand the names and addresses of over 3,000 pastors here in Brazil. I prepared a two-color leaflet introducing and explaining the proposal and mailed it to all of them. The result was total rejection. Even so, four of us with the same vision opened the school in August, 1996. It staggered along for 2.5 years and died ignominiously in December, 1998. The main difficulty was that the churches were destroying the faith of their young people, so there simply were not candidates for the type of worker that I wanted to prepare. But I had not realized that yet, at the time.

Now then, I am a slave of Sovereign Jesus, and I am satisfied that it was He who gave me the vision for that school. I had to raise the 'banner' of those three qualities. To this day I believe that if we could prepare an army with those qualities, we would take the world. However, the evangelical leadership of the country absolutely rejected the proposal. So my dream was dead, and I said to my Owner: "Now what, Owner, what do you want me to do now?" And He answered me: "From now on your job will be to do that for which I created you; I created you to promote the objective authority of the Biblical Text, especially the New Testament." So I said: "Yes, sir." (I was 64 years old at the time.)

Well now, it is easy to say, 'promote the objective authority of the NT', but how does one do it in practice? I spent a year or two spinning my wheels, trying a bit of this and a bit of that. Then it came to me: there are at least eight different editions of the Greek NT in the marketplace; so which of them should I choose, in order to promote its objective authority? Objective authority depends upon a defined wording, since the meaning depends on the wording. I was already in the Majority Text camp, having been the first president of the Majority Text Society. During that time I had tried to formulate a majority text theory, but had been defeated by the hundreds of places where there simply is no majority text; no one of the variant readings has 50% attestation from the extant Greek manuscripts. That said, most of the time the majority is at least 95% of the MSS, which means that such readings dominated the history of transmission down

through the centuries; they are attested by the vast majority of the lines of transmission. So they are presumably original. However, for some 2% of the words of the NT the majority falls below 80%, which is less 'comfortable'. Nonetheless, the Hodges-Farstad Majority Text appeared to me to be the logical place to start.

It was the Hodges-Farstad Majority Text's representation of the evidence for the episode of the adulterous woman that occupies John 7:53-8:11 that caught my attention, being based on von Soden's collation of over 900 MSS for those twelve verses. As stated in their apparatus, there were three main streams: $\mathbf{M}^{5}$, $\mathbf{M}^{6}$ and $\mathbf{M}^{7}$ ($\mathbf{M}^{1\text{-}4}$ are small, all together they are less than half the size of any of the big ones). **7** was always in the majority [except for one five-way split where there is no majority] because it was always accompanied by either **5** or **6** [5 + 6 never go against 7]. This looked to me like three independent streams, or lines of transmission, where seldom would more than one go astray at any given point. But if one of the streams never goes astray, it is the 'core', it is the 'point of reference', it is the common denominator. Therefore, **7** was clearly the best of the three, and presumably also the oldest.

Then I went to Revelation (in H-F) and noticed three main streams again: $\mathbf{M}^{a\text{-}b}$, $\mathbf{M}^{c}$ and $\mathbf{M}^{d\text{-}e}$. The picture was analogous to that of the episode. Revelation represents a very much larger corpus than does the *PA*, but even so, there are only 16 clear cases where **a-b** and **d-e** join against **c** (+ 11 others where one of them is split), and only two of those 27 cases make any real difference in the meaning. That compares to 153 places where **a-b** and **c** join against **d-e** and to 174 places where **c** and **d-e** join against **a-b**. Again, if one of the streams seldom goes astray, it is the 'core', it is the 'point of reference', it is the common denominator, so **c** was clearly the best of the three (see the apparatus of my Greek Text of the Apocalypse).

Now then, it so happens that $\mathbf{M}^{7}$ in John and $\mathbf{M}^{c}$ in Revelation equal my Family 35. So I said to myself, '**If it is the best line of transmission in John and Revelation, it just might be the best elsewhere as well'**. To check that out I would need to collate a representative number of MSS from the family. And to do that I would need to develop a provisional archetypal form of the family's text. That is simply a question of efficiency; a MS must be collated against a base text, and the closer it is to that text, the fewer variants there will be in the apparatus. I started with the Gospels because I had the numbers for 127 perfect family representatives for the episode. Fortunately for me, F.H.A. Scrivener had published collations of fifty MSS, four of which were F35. Most F35 MSS were so carefully copied that with just four of them I was able to produce a provisional base text. For example, as I recall, for Matthew I made only 16 changes for the final form.

Special recognition must be given to the INTF in Münster, Germany. Their *Text und Textwert* series began to appear in 1987. Their *Editio Critica Maior* series began to appear in 1997. Their *Kurzgefasste Liste* was published in 1994. I have copies of all that have been published to date. In 2001 I started to make heavy use of them. Now then, to collate a MS you must have access to a copy, and back then there were no copies on the internet. I began by buying duplicate microfilms of selected MSS. A microfilm has reduced the size of the frames 20 times, so in order to read it you must find a machine that reads microfilms and restores the frames to the original size. The national Congress here in Brasília has such machines, which I was able to use. But it is a time-consuming process; you convert each frame to PDF, one by one, and then copy the PDFs onto your pendrive. At home I printed the frames, one by one, so I had a paper copy to collate. Bit by bit, it became possible to buy paper copies from the libraries that had the MSS, and also copies in PDF. Today most extant MSS are freely available in PDF from the internet. How times have changed!

It was von Soden who first identified Family 35 as a line of transmission, and he called it $\mathbf{K^r}$, considering it to be a late revision of his $\mathbf{K^x}$, and the academic world has generally followed von Soden to this day. However, since $\mathbf{M^7}$ in John and $\mathbf{M^c}$ in Revelation equal my Family 35, I began to smell a rat. Why 'smelled a rat'? Because $\mathbf{M^7}$ is clearly older than $\mathbf{M^5}$ and $\mathbf{M^6}$ in the episode, and $\mathbf{M^c}$ is clearly older than $\mathbf{M^{a\text{-}b}}$ and $\mathbf{M^{d\text{-}e}}$ in Revelation, but von Soden claimed $\mathbf{K^r}$ was a revision of $\mathbf{K^x}$. How could it be a revision if it was older than what it supposedly revised? How could it be a revision if it already existed before the supposed revision was made?

Also, the *Text und Textwert* series proved that $\mathbf{K^r}$ is independent of $\mathbf{K^x}$ throughout the NT. It follows that $\mathbf{K^r}$ <u>cannot</u> be a revision of $\mathbf{K^x}$. Then there are hundreds of places where $\mathbf{K^r}$ has overt early attestation, against $\mathbf{K^x}$, but there is no pattern to that early attestation. There being no pattern then $\mathbf{K^r}$ must be early, as the picture in the episode and in Revelation has already implied. If $\mathbf{K^r}$ is early and independent, then it must be rehabilitated in the practice of NT textual criticism. Since it is not a revision, $\mathbf{K^r}$ should no longer be used. Those who do not want to use $\mathbf{f^{35}}$ should use $\mathbf{f^{18}}$.

By the time I published the Greek New Testament according to Family 35 in early 2014, I had collated a minimum of 20 MSS for each book and over 30 MSS for most of them. Now I have collated 58, 65, 56 and 63 respectively for the four Gospels; no fewer than 44 for Acts and the General Epistles; no fewer than 34 for Paul's letters; and 31 for Revelation, besides Hoskier's collations. I have collated a perfect copy of the family archetype for 23 of the 27 NT books. For another three I have collated a complete copy; with corrections and alternates not a single letter has been lost. For the last one, Acts, I have collated one copy

that misses being complete by one word and two letters. The best copy that I have is perfect for 17 of the books, and it is from the 15th century. That means that all of its ancestors down through the centuries were also perfect for those books! Anyone who has collated a number of MSS will understand when I say that such a perfect transmission is supernatural.

My claim that the Holy Spirit used the line of transmission that I call Family 35 to preserve the precise original wording of the NT is based on objective evidence. That evidence is presented in detail in my book, *God Has Preserved His Text! The Divine Preservation of the New Testament*, now in its seventh edition. It can be purchased from Amazon or downloaded from my website: www.prunch.org.